

Comparisons make no sense

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Suresh Menon

With Liverpool paying 169 million dollars as transfer fee for the Swedish striker Alexander Isak (in pic), the question that is always hanging on the edge of professional sport moves to the centre again. Are sports stars overpaid?

The economist's response usually is that a player receives what the market determines. The emotional fan's is more complicated, and brings in comparisons with teachers and doctors and soldiers who never see even a small percentage of such figures on their cheques.

There are, of course doctors and others who are overpaid; in fact, when I first became a sports editor all those years ago, I thought I was being overpaid! And doubtless even those who make over a million dollars at the IPL feel they are being underpaid. Rishabh Pant was bought by Lucknow Super Giants for just 3.21 million dollars, after all. Comparisons make no sense. In any case, Lionel Messi earning 135 million dollars (like he did last year) does not deprive the teachers and doctors of their salaries. It is not about relative value. They operate in different economies.

The argument about being paid a fortune for 'merely kicking a ball or getting it through a hoop or beating someone to a pulp doesn't hold either. Athletes don't get paid only for their skill on the field, but for the millions they bring into the sport and into the pockets of their sponsors.

In the last financial year, Cristiano Ronaldo made 260



million dollars from his sport and endorsements. No one made more.

Two years ago, the LA Dodgers forked out 700 million dollars over 10 years for Shohei Ohtani. Will it make the Japanese baseballer a better player and will the Dodgers make a profit on the deal? The honest answers are 'maybe', and 'yes'. At any rate, someone thinks he is worth that much, and that's all that matters.

Careers are short, and injuries could make them shorter. Athletes, goes the counter argument, sacrifice a lot, lead disciplined lives and give up much in pursuit of their goals.

This is true, but that could apply to any professional.

In our hurry to reconcile market realities with nostalgia ("in the 1960s, Indian cricketers were paid just 250 rupees a day for a Test match..."), we slip into one or the other side. But LeBron James doesn't just dunk; he practically runs a global media empire while dragging his team into playoff contention and headlines. These are not just athletes — they are industries in sneakers who bring in millions in television rights, merchandising and more. Salaries paid by clubs are investments.

There is an honesty to sport. The exposure is ruthless. You can't politick your way into scoring a World Cup goal or get into a Grand Slam tournament because you have an influential uncle who knows somebody. Sport as an activity might be one of the most meaningless things we do, but the pressures are real, tensions can destroy. Can you imagine the pressure on Isak from now on?